



Romantic competence in established relationships: Perceptual, behavioral, interactive, and assortative components

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ABSTRACT

Romantic competence (RC) may benefit relationships, but the mechanisms responsible for such links have yet to receive sufficient attention. The present investigation assessed RC levels among participants and their romantic partners (171 couples) using a recently-developed situational judgment test and the design of the study permitted the examination of multiple pathways through which RC could benefit relationships. High RC participants generally viewed relationships in more positive terms and they were also more satisfied with their current relationships. They contributed to the relationship satisfaction of their partners through behavioral pathways and the RC levels of participants and partners were systematically correlated. Altogether, the research highlights multiple mechanisms that link romantic competence to relationship functioning.

1. Introduction

Despite the health and well-being benefits of close romantic relationships (Holt-Lunstad, Robles, & Sbarra, 2017), most such relationships do not survive (Martin & Bumpass, 1989), and many that do can be a source of conflict and misery (Gottman, 1999). A problem here is that maintaining healthy relationships requires skills (Burleson, 1995) and many people may lack such skills (Farmer & Chapman, 2016). Conflicts inevitably arise and it is natural to respond to them in reactive manners (Berkowitz, 1993), but doing so can give rise to destructive communication patterns or aggression (Olson & Golish, 2002). Conversely, maintaining relationships can often require “transforming one’s motivations” such that they guide one toward long-term considerations, even in contexts in which doing so is difficult (Rusbult, Verette, Whitney, Slovik, & Lipkus, 1991). Other relationship skills are important, too, such as those that would promote trust, perspective taking, or intimacy development (Gottman, 1999; Mikulincer, 2006).

Like social skills in general (Dirks, Treat, & Weersing, 2007), the skills important to romantic relationships are likely to operate in a situation-specific manner. One needs to make accurate inferences about what is occurring within a particular moment (Kozlowski, 2013) and one also needs to adjust one’s behaviors such that they are responsive to the situation at hand (Farmer & Chapman, 2016). As an example, frank expressions of disapproval are likely to be beneficial under some

circumstances (e.g., when the partner has violated an important relationship rule: Baxter, 1986), but not others (Overall & McNulty, 2017). Similarly, assertiveness and self-expression are important in some circumstances, but warmth and social support are important in others (Farmer & Chapman, 2016; Mikulincer, 2006). Such considerations led to the development of a new measure of romantic competence (or RC) that fully embraces the situational nature of skillful relationship behavior, specifically by building on a situational judgment test (SJT: Corstjens, Lievens, & Krumm, 2017) model (Robinson, Penzel, & Persich, in press).

In this research (Robinson et al., in press), undergraduates in romantic relationships were asked how they would respond to a series of relationship threats or challenges, described in situational terms, and whether such responses are competent or not was determined by comparing them to an external key focused on the effectiveness (versus ineffectiveness) of the relevant actions (Corstjens et al., 2017). The resulting measure – termed the RC-BT – was uncorrelated with cognitive ability, but displayed expected, though modest, correlations with personality and attachment style (see Method section for further details). Of more importance, it predicted self-reports of relationship-related empathy and perspective taking (positively), aggression toward one’s partner (negatively), and extradyadic sexual behavior (negatively) even when controlling for variations in personality or attachment style, suggesting that the measure may capture new sources of variance that

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matter in the conduct of romantic relationships. Another study indicated that high RC individuals felt closer to their partners on the average day, but the mechanisms linking RC to relationship functioning were largely unexplored in these original studies.

Before detailing the foci of the present investigation, it may be useful to offer some general theorizing. Situational judgment tests can be used to simulate the challenges, threats, and uncertainties that occur within a given domain (Lievens & De Soete, 2012). When responses to those situations are scored using an effectiveness key, the resulting individual differences are thought to tap the knowledge, skills, and abilities (KSAs) necessary to perform well in that domain (Lievens & De Soete, 2012). In the area of romantic relationships, relevant KSAs are likely to involve capacities related to effective communication, mutuality in the relationship, social support, intimacy development, emotion regulation, and conflict management (Davila et al., 2021; Lawrence et al., 2008). Because such KSAs are diverse, we also offer a broader perspective. Dual-process theorizing (e.g., Carver, Johnson, & Joormann, 2009) contrasts one mode of self-regulation that is reflexive and emotional with another mode of self-regulation that is reflective – that is, guided by longer-term considerations (Hall & Fong, 2007). This reflexive-reflective distinction may have considerable merit in understanding variations in RC, with reflexivity mapped to low RC levels and reflectivity mapped to high RC levels.

The present research sought to investigate the multiple ways in which RC may be important within romantic relationships and it sought to do so in the context of established rather than emerging relationships. Through the application of their relationship skills, individuals with higher levels of RC should be more capable of crafting successful romantic relationships, whether past or present. Such histories of comparative success should give rise to more favorable views of relationships in general terms. By contrast, through their struggles in their relationships, low RC individuals are likely to view relationships as problematic, giving rise to a greater frequency of doubts and concerns (Doron, Derby, Szepeswol, & Talmor, 2012).

Through the application of their skills, high RC, relative to low RC, individuals should be more capable of creating and maintaining well-functioning relationships, defined as those that are rewarding, interdependent, and intimate (Hassebrauck & Fehr, 2002). Such considerations lead to the prediction that high RC participants should be more satisfied with their current relationships (which are in fact better ones). Through their supportive behaviors, high RC individuals should also be capable of creating supportive partners (Hudson, Fraley, Chloe, Brumbaugh, & Vicary, 2014), which we define in terms of partners who are more accessible, responsive, and engaged (Sandberg, Bradford, & Brown, 2017). Such considerations led us to predict that high RC participants would characterize partner behaviors in such terms.

As conceptualized, romantic competence is defined in behavioral terms (Robinson et al., *in press*) and it should predict the behaviors that one exhibits in one's relationship. Along these lines, we hypothesized that participants with higher RC levels would display higher levels of accessibility, responsiveness, and engagement within their relationships, as reported on by partners rather than participants, and we hypothesized that partners would characterize the behaviors of high RC participants as more communicative and prosocial. Given that low RC individuals seem to be prone to aggression in their relationships (Robinson et al., *in press*), we further hypothesized that partners would ascribe lower levels of antisocial behavior and mistreatment to the extent that the participant possessed high rather than low levels of RC. Owing to such behavioral processes, we further hypothesized that partners would be more satisfied in their relationships with high RC participants (that is, participant RC levels should predict *both* one's own satisfaction in the relationship and the satisfaction levels of partners).

We were also interested in ways in which RC could shape relationships even at their outset. Preferring a certain type of partner has been shown to play a causal role in assortative mating (Campbell, Chin, & Stanton, 2016) and such preferences have been broadly classified into

qualities related to warmth-loyalty, vitality-attractiveness, and status-resources (Fletcher & Simpson, 2000). That is, one might generally prefer a partner who is warm and kind (rather than cold and mean), physically attractive (rather than not), and capable of bringing resources to the relationship (rather than not), but maximizing all qualities at once would be difficult (Fletcher & Simpson, 2000). Warmth and kindness are particularly important to creating close, intimate relationships (Valentine, Li, Meltzer, & Tsai, 2020) and these qualities seem most pertinent to relationship quality (Rodríguez, Hadden, & Knee, 2015). As relationship experts, participants with high RC levels are likely to be more sensitive to such dynamics and we hypothesized that higher levels of romantic competence would be linked to higher valuing of intrinsic attributes such as kindness and openness relative to extrinsic attributes such as status or money.

Assortative mating processes were also examined in two other manners. First, we were interested in whether high RC individuals would be more skilled in choosing partners who match their ideals, as defined in terms of a correlation between preferred partner qualities and actual partner qualities, as rated by partners concerning themselves (Murray et al., 2011). Second, we were interested in perhaps the more fundamental question of whether romantic competence itself would lend itself to assortative mating, as quite a few individual differences do (Luo, 2017). Being competent at relationships should allow high RC individuals to better recognize competence in others (Dunning, Johnson, Ehrlinger, & Kruger, 2003) and, if so, we might expect the RC levels of participants and partners to be systematically correlated, implicating assortative mating with respect to such skills (Luo, 2017). A correlation of this type would suggest that high RC participants could thrive in their relationships *both* because they have the skills necessary to support them (Robinson et al., *in press*) and because they select partners who are *also* more skilled. The study design allowed us to speak to processes of this type.

Before describing data collection efforts, we should say a bit more about the RC-BT measure. Through an SJT platform (Corstjens et al., 2017), participants are asked how they would respond to a series of relationship challenges and uncertainties (e.g., a partner flirting with another person). An assumption of this platform is that how one responds to hypothetical situations is a good indicator of how they would respond to similar events in real life (Lievens & De Soete, 2012). There is evidence in support of this assumption (Corstjens et al., 2017; Mussel, Gatzka, & Hewig, 2018; Tangney et al., 1996) and we will say more about such evidence in the Discussion section.

2. Method

2.1. Participants, recruitment, and screening procedures

We sought to recruit adult romantic dyads who were in established relationships. This objective was achieved through a contract with TurkPrime, which is a data collection support company that has developed procedures for extending Amazon's Mechanical Turk (MTurk) interface. On MTurk, the study was advertised as a "Dyadic Romantic Relationship Study" to qualified participants who were over 20 years old, who were currently in romantic relationships that had lasted longer than three months. Participants were informed that both they and their partners would need to complete reports before compensation would be awarded. Participants who agreed to these terms began a survey, which was programmed with Qualtrics software. Upon completion of this survey, participants were given pre-written email text that they sent to their relationship partners, along with their own MTurk ID numbers, which were used to match participants and partners.

Data quality was maximized in several ways, beginning with the fact that participants were required to have a master's level MTurk rating. In addition, attention and speeding checks were added to both participant and partner surveys. Finally, we wanted to ensure that participants and partners were, in fact, different people. One way this was done was by

comparing the IP addresses generated from the Qualtrics surveys. Even so, it would be reasonable for married, cohabitating, or other long-term couples to share a computer or computer network, thus producing the same IP address. We therefore added another check by asking both partners and participants to provide consent by writing “I agree to participate in this study on [date]” on a piece of paper. Subsequently, the writer was asked to take a digital picture of their hand holding the note and upload this digital picture with their surveys. We then compared participant and partner pictures. Dyads were excluded if one member of the dyad failed a speeding or attention check, the couple failed both the IP-matching procedure and the picture test (e.g., by uploading a stock photo), or if one member of the dyad reported not being in a relationship.

We desired adequate power to detect medium effects for multiple regression analyses with up to four predictor variables, following precedent (Robinson et al., [in press](#)). A two-tailed power analysis using G*Power software recommended a sample size of 150 dyads, which we sought to exceed to guard against attrition. Participant surveys were started by 256 individuals, but 47 of these were unusable (e.g., due to failed attention checks). Among the remaining participants, 38 partners did not respond or provided unusable surveys. Ultimately, we obtained usable data from 171 couples. As indicated by the demographic information reported in [Table 1](#), couples tended to be in their mid-30 s and they were often involved in serious long-term relationships (e.g., marriages). Data for this project are available at <https://osf.io/k6h79/>.

2.2. Romantic competence assessment

The romantic competence (RC) levels of *both* participants and partners were assessed with a recently developed measure (Robinson et al., [in press](#)) that conceptualizes RC in terms of the social cognitive skills that support appropriate responding to threats, challenges, and uncertainties in a relationship, using a situational judgment model (Corstjens et al., 2017). Robinson et al. ([in press](#)) report, in detail, efforts related to generating the materials, selecting them, and evidence in support of the reliability and validity of the resulting measure. Accordingly, the test will be more briefly described in the context of the current research. Participants and partners were presented with 10 scenarios describing the relationship difficulties or challenges of a named protagonist and his/her unnamed “partner”, ranging from life-style differences to conflicts to serious issues such as a partner’s possible infidelity. The situations are written in a straightforward manner (e.g., “Donna senses that there is something wrong in her relationship”), both

to minimize contributions from cognitive ability and to promote broad applicability (Corstjens et al., 2017).

Each scenario is paired with 4 potential ways of responding to it. These responses are diverse and include acquiescing, hiding one’s feelings, seeking further information, confronting the partner, and/or doing something rash (e.g., stealing a partner’s phone, which has a Tinder account on it). All responses are plausible, but some could generate enmity (e.g., getting rid of Netflix because one’s partner likes to stay home to watch it), whereas others would seem more likely to “work”, either by diffusing the situation or at least by clarifying it so that a resolution is possible (e.g., through frank discussion). The 10 scenarios and 40 ways of responding were chosen to cover a variety of relationship issues that couples often have as well as on the basis of psychometric considerations (Robinson et al., [in press](#)).

Participants and partners were asked to place themselves into the situation of each named protagonist. They were then asked to indicate the likelihood (1 = extremely unlikely; 5 = extremely likely) that they would respond to each described situation in each of the four described ways. In the situational judgment test literature, this instructional frame is thought to capture processes related to decision-making and behavior, with the idea that how a person responds to simulated events and contexts is likely to capture the same sorts of processes that elicit behavior in real life (Corstjens et al., 2017). The goal of RC measurement is to quantify the extent to which particular individuals respond to simulated relationship challenges in ways that are helpful and practical (or competent) rather than immature and reactive (or incompetent).

This computation is done by linking the self-likelihood ratings of respondents to an external set of ratings intended to capture the effectiveness of the relevant actions (Grover, Nangle, Serwik, Fales, & Pre-noveau, 2013). Briefly, 148 participants in romantic relationships were asked to rate the effectiveness (1 = not effective at all; 5 = extremely effective) of each way of responding to each situation, irrespective of what the self would do (McDaniel, Hartman, Whetzel, & Grubb, 2007). Effective actions solve a problem, preserve the relationship, benefit the self, and demonstrate competence, whereas ineffective actions exacerbate problems, do not solve them, create further difficulties to the relationship, and/or are impulsive and short-sighted (Robinson et al., [in press](#)). To act effectively in romantic relationships likely requires assertiveness (even when assertive actions make one nervous), honesty (even when one desires to be dishonest), considering the other’s perspective (even when one desires to only consider the self’s perspective), and thinking about the long-term consequences of an action (even when impulses press for a short-term solution). The romantic relationship domain, like the health domain (Robinson, Irvin, & Persich, 2022), is one in which people likely know how they should behave (e.g., by exercising, eating vegetables, avoiding excess), but often do not (Hall & Fong, 2007). Thus, it is meaningful to link the behaviors of the self to an external effectiveness key.

The scoring system therefore awards points when a respondent gives high self-likelihood ratings to actions deemed to be effective (by others) and low self-likelihood ratings to actions deemed to be ineffective. By contrast, a respondent would receive a low RC score if he or she endorsed actions (e.g., impulsive, reactive ones) that would likely be problematic while failing to endorse actions (e.g., that are effortful but more promising) that are deemed (by others) to be effective. [Table 2](#) gives a concrete example of how this scoring system works. In response to a scenario involving suspicions of cheating, our hypothetical participant indicated that he or she would be very unlikely (1 rating) to secretly follow the partner around. Following the partner around was deemed to be very ineffective according to the scoring key, in that roughly 51% of that sample gave a 1 rating for the effectiveness of this behavior. Accordingly, the participant would receive a high score for this response. On the other hand, the participant would be inclined to snoop too much given the ineffectiveness of this behavior and their willingness to use a confrontation strategy seems low relative to the effectiveness of this strategy, resulting in a fairly modest overall score

Table 1
Participant and partner demographics.

	Participant	Partner
Age	33.54 (9.09)	34.92 (10.23)
% Female	60.82%	38.60%
% Caucasian	80.12%	76.02%
% Heterosexual	95.91%	95.32%
Relationship Status		
Casually Dating	0%	
Dating	1.75%	
Exclusive Relationship	34.50%	
Engaged	11.11%	
Married	52.63%	
Length of Current Relationship		
Less than 3 months	0%	
3–6 months	0.58%	
6–12 months	4.68%	
1–2 years	12.87%	
2–4 years	18.12%	
4–7 years	19.88%	
More than 7 years	43.86%	

Table 2

Procedures of the RC-BT (with BT referring to “behavioral tendencies”): example scenario, effectiveness norms, hypothetical responses, and their scoring.

Scenario: Roger is suspicious that his partner has cheated, but has no proof.							
Instructions: If you were in the situation, how likely would it be that YOU would do the following? 1 = extremely unlikely; 5 = extremely likely							
Ways of responding: i. Secretly follow her around; ii. Start snooping around for evidence; iii. Get his best friend to find out; iv. Confront the partner							
Way	Effectiveness Norms					S. Rate	Score
	1	2	3	4	5		
i. Follow	51%	41%	07%	01%	00%	1	0.51
ii. Snoop	39%	43%	14%	04%	00%	3	0.14
iii. Friend	27%	46%	22%	04%	01%	4	0.04
iv. Confront	02%	03%	21%	32%	42%	3	0.21

Note: The hypothetical participant gave self-likelihood ratings (S.Rat.) of 1, 3, 4, and 3, and the participant’s RC-BT score for this scenario would be 0.2250 (the average of 0.51, 0.14, 0.04, and 0.21).

(0.2250) for the cheating scenario. The total RC score then averages across scenarios.

Descriptive statistics for the RC measure accorded with Robinson et al. (in press). Average scores hovered around 0.30 (participants: 0.3313; partners: 0.2965), but standard deviations (participants: 0.0780; partners: 0.0755) also indicated the presence of pronounced individual differences. Internal reliability estimates, computed across the 10 scenarios of the test, were good (participants: 0.84; partners: 0.80).

What the RC-BT captures does not overlap with general mental ability, as captured by a combination of ACT scores and GPA, $r = 0.03$, $p = .667$ (as reported by Robinson et al., in press). Correlations with personality are modest (agreeableness: $r = 0.18$, $p = .019$; neuroticism: $r = -0.32$, $p < .001$), as are correlations with attachment style (anxious attachment: $r = -0.33$, $p < .001$; avoidant attachment: $r = -0.17$, $p = .025$). Furthermore, Robinson et al. (in press) found that the RC-BT predicted (self-reported) relationship outcomes even when controlling for personality or attachment style. The KSAs assessed by the RC-BT are therefore distinct from personality and attachment style.

2.3. Participant-reported outcomes

We assessed several participant-reported outcomes to examine (a) whether high RC participants have more benevolent views of relationships, in general, (b) whether they have more positive perceptions of their partners in particular, and (c) whether they are more satisfied with their relationships.

2.3.1. Romantic attitudes scale

Owing to a history of success in the romantic relationship domain, we reasoned that high RC participants would typically view relationships in more positive terms. To examine this possibility, we asked participants whether they agreed (1 = strongly disagree; 5 = strongly agree) with statements linking relationships to evaluative adjectives (e. g., “I think romantic relationships are wonderful”; $M = 4.62$; $SD = 0.62$; $\alpha = 0.92$), following the attitude literature (Greenwald, McGhee, & Schwartz, 1998).

2.3.2. Relationship worries and concerns

By contrast, struggling in relationships should trigger more frequent worries and concerns. To assess such symptoms, we administered the Relationship Obsessive Compulsive Inventory (ROCI: Doron et al., 2012), which assesses obsessive symptoms related to the self’s love for the partner (e.g., “I feel that I must remind myself over and over again why I love my partner”; $M = 1.62$; $SD = 0.92$; $\alpha = 0.88$), the partner’s love for the self (e.g., “I keep asking my partner whether she/he really loves me”; $M = 1.74$; $SD = 1.06$; $\alpha = 0.95$), and the relationship as a whole ($M = 1.67$; $SD = 0.96$; $\alpha = 0.89$). We also computed an ROCI total

score ($M = 1.67$; $SD = 0.88$; $\alpha = 0.95$).

2.3.3. Perceptions of partner behavior

We suggested that high RC participants should be more capable of eliciting supportiveness from their partners. To examine questions of this type, we used the partner perception items from the BARE (Sandberg, Busby, Johnson, & Yoshida, 2012), which has separable subscales for partner accessibility ($M = 4.14$; $SD = 0.95$; $\alpha = 0.71$), responsiveness ($M = 4.10$; $SD = 0.92$; $\alpha = 0.75$), and engagement ($M = 4.20$ $SD = 0.97$; $\alpha = 0.83$).

2.3.4. Relationship satisfaction

Romantic competence should enable the creation of a more satisfying relationship (Burleson, 1995). To examine this hypothesis in overall terms, we administered the Relationship Assessment Scale (Hendrick, 1988), which is an often-used general purpose scale ($M = 5.77$; $SD = 1.07$; $\alpha = 0.82$).

2.3.5. Relationship quality

To assess relationship quality in a more detailed manner, we also administered the Perceived Relationship Quality Components Scale (PRQC: Fletcher, Simpson, & Thomas, 2000), which defines relationship quality in terms of satisfaction ($M = 5.98$; $SD = 1.18$; $\alpha = 0.93$), commitment ($M = 6.45$; $SD = 0.91$; $\alpha = 0.92$), intimacy ($M = 5.95$; $SD = 1.12$; $\alpha = 0.92$), trust ($M = 6.08$; $SD = 1.22$; $\alpha = 0.87$), passion ($M = 4.97$; $SD = 1.53$; $\alpha = 0.89$), and love ($M = 6.29$; $SD = 1.12$; $\alpha = 0.93$). We also computed a PRQC total score ($M = 5.95$; $SD = 0.98$; $\alpha = 0.96$).

2.4. Partner-reported outcomes

Because the RC-BT focuses on behavioral processes, it should predict emitted behaviors. In more particular terms, we hypothesized that partners would report that the behaviors of high RC participants, relative to low RC participants, tend to be more helpful and supportive as well as less hostile and reactive. In part because of such behavioral processes, we hypothesized that the partners of high RC individuals should experience higher levels of satisfaction with their relationships.

2.4.1. Perceptions of participant behavior

Partners reported on how frequently (1 = never; 5 = often) participants communicated with them (5 items; e.g., “communicates with me”: $M = 4.26$; $SD = 0.80$; $\alpha = 0.89$) while exhibiting prosocial behavior (5 items; e.g., “forgives me when I make mistakes”: $M = 4.01$; $SD = 0.83$; $\alpha = 0.86$). In addition, partners reported on how frequently participants mistreated them (5 items; e.g., “mistreats me”: $M = 1.30$; $SD = 0.65$; $\alpha = 0.90$) while exhibiting antisocial behavior (5 items; e.g., “lies to me”: $M = 1.33$; $SD = 0.63$; $\alpha = 0.88$). These scales were modeled on those of Cui, Lorenz, Conger, Melby, and Bryant (2005).

2.4.2. Perceptions of attachment behavior

Partners reported on how accessible ($M = 4.14$; $SD = 0.95$; $\alpha = 0.77$), responsive ($M = 4.10$; $SD = 0.96$; $\alpha = 0.76$), and engaged ($M = 4.02$; $SD = 1.06$; $\alpha = 0.77$) the participant was in his/her conduct of the relationship (Sandberg et al., 2012).

2.4.3. Relationship satisfaction and quality

Participants with higher RC levels are likely to be more satisfying relationship partners. To examine dyadic processes of this type, we asked partners to report on their satisfaction levels with the relationship, using the RAS (Hendrick, 1988: $M = 5.86$; $SD = 1.04$; $\alpha = 0.80$). In addition, partners completed the PRQC (Fletcher et al., 2000) and its satisfaction ($M = 6.15$; $SD = 1.09$; $\alpha = 0.92$), commitment ($M = 6.52$; $SD = 0.90$; $\alpha = 0.88$), intimacy ($M = 6.10$; $SD = 1.20$; $\alpha = 0.92$), trust ($M = 6.32$; $SD = 1.11$; $\alpha = 0.89$), passion ($M = 5.26$; $SD = 1.59$; $\alpha = 0.92$), and love ($M = 6.47$; $SD = 0.98$; $\alpha = 0.92$) subscales. We also computed a partner-based PRQC total score ($M = 6.14$; $SD = 0.97$; $\alpha = 0.97$).

2.5. Dyadic preferences

We were interested in several assortative processes that may vary by RC levels. To examine questions of this type, we compiled a list of seven attributes that varied in whether they referred to more superficial features (money or earning potential, social status, physical attractiveness), desirable abilities (intelligence), or deeper, more intrinsic (Rodriguez et al., 2015) partner qualities (expressiveness and openness, similarity in attitudes and values, warmth and kindness), compiled from mate preference studies. To pit these qualities against each other and therefore maximize variance, participants were asked to rank order the characteristics in terms of their importance in a potential mate (1 = most important quality; 7 = least important quality; *Ms* were 5.32, 6.37, 4.32, 3.15, 3.80, 2.63, & 2.40 for money, social status, physical attractiveness, intelligence, expressiveness, similarity, & warmth, respectively). Partners were also presented with the same characteristics, but were instead asked to rank them in terms of how much they personally possessed the qualities in question (1 = this is my strongest quality; 7 = this is my weakest quality; *Ms* were 5.01, 6.01, 3.99, 3.05, 3.85, 3.24, & 2.84).

3. Results

3.1. Analysis overview

Initial analyses focused on the possibility that RC levels would vary by the demographic variables of sex, age, and relationship length. Aside from interest in such questions, we planned to control for predictors correlating with participant RC scores in follow-up analyses. In primary analyses, we then performed a series of simple regressions to examine questions pertaining to (a) whether participant RC levels predicted generalized beliefs and attitudes concerning relationships, (b) whether participant RC levels predicted participant-reported relationship outcomes, (c) whether participant RC levels predicted partner-reported outcomes, and (d) whether partner RC levels predicted partner-reported outcomes.

Potential mechanisms involving assortative mating were then examined. A first question was whether high RC participants tended to be paired with high RC partners. Assortative mating processes were further examined in terms of RC associations involving preferred partner qualities as well as links between such preferences and actual partner qualities (as reported on by partners). Because high RC participants tended to be dating high RC partners, we then conducted multiple regressions in which the RC levels of both individuals were treated as simultaneous predictors of both participant- and partner-reported outcomes. With respect to outcomes that are specific to the relationship, we generally expected both sets of RC scores to matter. Finally, we performed actor-partner interdependence modeling on the outcomes of relationship satisfaction and relationship quality, using the variable of sex to distinguish among dyad members.

3.2. Demographic aspects of romantic competence

Women often value their personal relationships to a greater extent and such investments could, over time, come to support higher levels of relationship competence (Felmlee & Muraco, 2009). In fact, participant levels of RC (as we assessed it) varied by sex in a between-groups ANOVA, $F(1, 170) = 4.86, p = .023, \eta_p^2 = 0.03$ (*Ms* = 0.3444 & 0.2854 for women and men). However, sex differences were not observed with respect to partner RC scores, $F(1, 170) = 2.36, p = .126, \eta_p^2 = 0.01$.

It also seemed feasible that RC scores would increase with age, which, on average, would be linked to more extensive relationship knowledge and experience (Meier & Allen, 2009). Consistent with this wisdom-based perspective, there were significant correlations between age and RC for both participants, $r = 0.23, p = .003$, and partners, $r = 0.24, p = .002$. In addition, participants, $r = 0.19, p = .013$, and partners, $r = 0.19, p = .013$, with higher RC levels had been in their current

relationships for a longer period of time. These correlations make sense, but could also represent potential confounds. We therefore controlled for sex, age, and relationship length in follow-up analyses. In the sections that follow, findings are organized in terms of particular subsets of data and the specific questions that they speak to (also see Table 3, which reports correlations among variables).

3.3. Do participant RC levels predict generalized views concerning relationships?

Simple and multiple regressions were performed to examine whether participants with higher RC levels view relationships more positively while being less prone to relationship-related worries and concerns. As displayed in Table 4, both such relationships were robust, with β s around $|0.40|$. That is, high RC individuals viewed relationships (in general) more positively and they were less prone to worries and concerns. Furthermore, these associations remained significant when controlling for sex, age, and relationship length (also see Table 4 and its multiple regression statistics).

3.4. Do participant RC levels predict perceptions of one's current relationship?

Simple and multiple regressions were next performed to examine participant-reported outcomes related to partner perceptions and relationship quality, from the self's perspective. Participants with higher RC levels characterized their partners as more accessible, responsive, and engaged in the relationship (Table 5). In addition, participants with higher RC levels were more satisfied with their relationships. A consideration of PRQC subscales revealed that links of this type were fairly ubiquitous in that the RC-BT was a positive predictor of participant experiences of satisfaction, commitment, intimacy, trust, passion, and love for one's partner. Such associations remained significant when controlling for sex, age, and relationship length (Table 5 multiple regression results).

3.5. Do participant RC levels predict partner-reported outcomes?

Participants with higher RC levels perceived their partners to be more accessible, responsive, and engaged within the relationship. Such perceptions were reciprocal in that partners, too, reported that participants with high RC levels were more accessible, responsive, and engaged (see Table 6). Accordingly, the data suggest that romantically competent people have relationships that are mutually supportive and rewarding.

Romantic competence can be thought of in terms of enacted knowledge – i.e., knowledge that should translate into actual behaviors within a relationship. This perspective received support in the form of partner reports of behavior. Participants who obtained higher RC scores were perceived to be more communicative in the relationship and they engaged in a greater frequency of prosocial behaviors, according to partners. Conversely, participants who obtained low RC scores were more prone to mistreating their partners and to acting in generally antisocial ways within the relationship (see Table 6).

Accessibility, responsiveness, and engagement should matter for partner satisfaction and similar dynamics should occur as the result of participant tendencies toward prosocial and antisocial behavior (Sandberg et al., 2017). Consistent with this analysis, partners experienced higher levels of relationship satisfaction with participants who had higher RC levels. Furthermore, this dyadic cross-over was a fairly substantial one that was reflected in partner reports of satisfaction, commitment, intimacy, trust, and love, with an especially strong association between participant RC and partner commitment, $\beta = 0.49$. Thus, relationships involving high RC participants appeared to be better for both participants and partners.

Table 3
Correlations among key variables.

Variable	1.	2.	3.	4.	5.	6.	7.	8.	9.	10.	11.	12.	13.
Predictors													
1. Participant RC	–												
2. Partner RC	0.53*	–											
Participant Reported Outcomes													
3. Relationship Attitudes	0.43*	0.27*	–										
4. ROCI Total	–0.50*	–0.39*	–0.54*	–									
5. BARE Total	0.40*	0.32*	0.47*	–0.67*	–								
6. Relationship Satisfaction	0.33*	0.29*	0.48*	–0.53*	0.65*	–							
7. Relationship Quality	0.51*	0.38*	0.62*	–0.63*	0.71*	0.68*	–						
Partner Reported Outcomes													
8. BARE Total	0.37*	0.36*	0.46*	–0.40*	0.61*	0.41*	0.52*	–					
9. Communication	0.44*	0.36*	0.43*	–0.35*	0.53*	0.34*	0.53*	0.73*	–				
10. Prosocial Behaviors	0.38*	0.36*	0.42*	–0.32*	0.50*	0.41*	0.54*	0.61*	0.67*	–			
11. Mistreatment	–0.38*	–0.41*	–0.46*	0.40*	–0.38*	–0.22	–0.41*	–0.52*	–0.52*	–0.51*	–		
12. Antisocial Behavior	–0.44*	–0.39*	–0.40*	0.34*	–0.36*	–0.18	–0.37*	–0.51*	–0.49*	–0.46*	0.82*	–	
13. Relationship Satisfaction	0.36*	0.32*	0.43*	–0.35*	0.55*	0.57*	0.50*	0.61*	0.63*	0.57*	–0.47*	–0.46*	–
14. Relationship Quality	0.34*	0.34*	0.49*	–0.39*	0.60*	0.44*	0.70*	0.69*	0.76*	0.67*	–0.51*	–0.54*	0.69*

Note: * $p < .001$.**Table 4**
Participant RC levels as a predictor of generalized relationship beliefs.

Outcome Measure	Simple Regression Results			Multiple Regression Results		
	<i>t</i>	<i>P</i>	β	<i>t</i>	<i>p</i>	β
Relationship Attitudes	6.23	<0.001	0.43 [0.30, 0.57]	5.63	<0.001	0.39 [0.26, 0.53]
Relationship Concerns						
Love for Partner	–7.35	<0.001	–0.49 [–0.63, –0.36]	–6.51	<0.001	–0.43 [–0.55, –0.30]
Loved by Partner	–6.20	<0.001	–0.43 [–0.59, –0.29]	–5.60	<0.001	–0.38 [–0.52, –0.25]
Relationship Rightness	–6.14	<0.001	–0.43 [–0.56, –0.29]	–5.82	<0.001	–0.41 [–0.55, –0.27]
ROCI Total Score	–7.43	<0.001	–0.53 [–0.63, –0.36]	–6.84	<0.001	–0.45 [–0.58, –0.32]

Note: ROCI = Relationship Obsessive Compulsive Inventory. The multiple regression statistics quantify RC/outcome relationships after controlling for gender, age, and relationship length.

Table 5
Participant RC levels as a predictor of perceptions of the partner and the relationship.

Outcome Measure	Simple Regression Results			Multiple Regression Results		
	<i>t</i>	<i>P</i>	β	<i>t</i>	<i>p</i>	β
BARE						
Accessibility	4.16	<0.001	0.30 [0.16, 0.45]	4.08	<0.001	0.30 [0.16, 0.46]
Responsiveness	5.49	<0.001	0.39 [0.25, 0.53]	5.36	<0.001	0.39 [0.25, 0.54]
Engagement	4.49	<0.001	0.33 [0.18, 0.47]	4.24	<0.001	0.32 [0.17, 0.47]
Relationship Satisfaction	4.61	<0.001	0.33 [0.19, 0.48]	4.24	<0.001	0.32 [0.17, 0.47]
Relationship Quality						
Satisfaction	5.71	<0.001	0.40 [0.26, 0.54]	5.71	<0.001	0.40 [0.26, 0.55]
Commitment	9.04	<0.001	0.57 [0.45, 0.70]	8.11	<0.001	0.51 [0.39, 0.64]
Intimacy	7.02	<0.001	0.48 [0.34, 0.61]	6.76	<0.001	0.48 [0.34, 0.62]
Trust	6.74	<0.001	0.44 [0.33, 0.60]	6.17	<0.001	0.44 [0.30, 0.58]
Passion	3.24	0.001	0.24 [0.09, 0.39]	3.82	<0.001	0.29 [0.14, 0.44]
Love	7.73	<0.001	0.51 [0.38, 0.64]	6.99	<0.001	0.48 [0.34, 0.61]
Total	7.77	<0.001	0.51 [0.38, 0.64]	7.33	<0.001	0.50 [0.37, 0.64]

Note: BARE = Brief Accessibility, Responsiveness, and Engagement Scale. The multiple regression statistics quantify RC/outcome relationships after controlling for participant gender, age, and relationship length.

3.6. Do partner RC levels predict partner-reported outcomes?

As displayed in Table 7, partners with higher RC levels perceived participants to be more accessible, responsive, and engaged. Also, partners were more satisfied with their relationships if they themselves obtained higher RC scores. Thus, conclusions based on participant levels

of RC and how they functioned were mirrored by partner levels of RC and how they functioned. Given these mirrored patterns, we sought to further understand them through the use of several dyad-focused analyses.

Table 6
Participant RC levels as a predictor of partner-reported outcomes.

Outcome measure		Simple regression results			Multiple regression results		
		<i>t</i>	<i>P</i>	β	<i>t</i>	<i>p</i>	β
BARE	Accessibility	5.48	<0.001	0.39 [0.25, 0.53]	5.13	<0.001	0.38 [0.23, 0.53]
	Responsiveness	3.70	<0.001	0.27 [0.13, 0.42]	3.36	0.002	0.24 [0.09, 0.39]
	Engagement	3.77	<0.001	0.28 [0.13, 0.42]	3.22	0.002	0.25 [0.10, 0.40]
Behaviors	Communication	6.29	<0.001	0.44 [0.30, 0.57]	5.65	<0.001	0.40 [0.36, 0.54]
	Prosocial	5.38	<0.001	0.38 [0.24, 0.52]	5.11	<0.001	0.38 [0.23, 0.52]
	Mistreatment	-5.39	<0.001	-0.38 [-0.52, -0.24]	-5.09	<0.001	-0.38 [-0.52, -0.23]
	Antisocial	-6.38	<0.001	-0.44 [-0.58, -0.30]	-6.18	<0.001	-0.44 [-0.59, -0.30]
Relationship Satisfaction		5.07	<0.001	0.36 [0.22, 0.51]	4.66	<0.001	0.35 [0.20, 0.49]
Relationship Quality							
	Satisfaction	5.57	<0.001	0.39 [0.26, 0.53]	5.33	<0.001	0.39 [0.25, 0.54]
	Commitment	8.21	<0.001	0.53 [0.41, 0.66]	7.37	<0.001	0.49 [0.36, 0.63]
	Intimacy	4.69	<0.001	0.34 [0.20, 0.48]	4.36	<0.001	0.33 [0.17, 0.47]
	Trust	5.90	<0.001	0.41 [0.28, 0.55]	5.28	<0.001	0.38 [0.24, 0.52]
	Passion	1.73	0.085	0.13 [-0.02, 0.28]	2.19	0.030	0.17 [0.02, 0.32]
	Love	6.62	<0.001	0.45 [0.32, 0.59]	5.83	<0.001	0.41 [0.27, 0.55]
	Total	5.94	<0.001	0.42 [0.28, 0.55]	5.55	<0.001	0.40 [0.26, 0.55]

Note: BARE = Brief Accessibility, Responsiveness, and Engagement Scale (perceptions of participant behavior). The multiple regression statistics quantify RC/outcome relationships after controlling for participant gender, age, and relationship length.

Table 7
Partner RC levels as a predictor of partner-reported outcomes.

Outcome measure		Simple regression results			Multiple regression results		
		<i>t</i>	<i>P</i>	β	<i>t</i>	<i>p</i>	β
BARE	Accessibility	4.31	<0.001	0.31 [0.17, 0.46]	4.05	<0.001	0.31 [0.16, 0.46]
	Responsiveness	5.09	<0.001	0.37 [0.22, 0.51]	4.64	<0.001	0.34 [0.20, 0.49]
	Engagement	3.16	<0.001	0.24 [0.09, 0.38]	2.65	0.009	0.21 [0.05, 0.36]
Behaviors	Communication	5.12	<0.001	0.36 [0.22, 0.50]	4.37	<0.001	0.32 [0.18, 0.49]
	Prosocial	5.52	<0.001	0.36 [0.25, 0.53]	5.25	<0.001	0.39 [0.24, 0.53]
	Mistreatment	-5.87	<0.001	-0.41 [-0.55, -0.27]	-5.47	<0.001	-0.40 [-0.55, -0.26]
	Antisocial	-5.53	<0.001	-0.39 [-0.53, -0.25]	-5.22	<0.001	-0.38 [-0.53, -0.24]
Relationship Satisfaction		4.40	<0.001	0.32 [0.18, 0.46]	4.03	<0.001	0.30 [0.16, 0.45]
Relationship Quality							
	Satisfaction	4.98	<0.001	0.36 [0.22, 0.50]	4.71	<0.001	0.35 [0.21, 0.50]
	Commitment	6.24	<0.001	0.43 [0.30, 0.57]	5.42	<0.001	0.39 [0.25, 0.53]
	Intimacy	3.52	<0.001	0.26 [0.11, 0.41]	3.13	0.002	0.24 [0.09, 0.39]
	Trust	4.77	<0.001	0.35 [0.20, 0.49]	4.14	<0.001	0.30 [0.16, 0.45]
	Passion	1.69	0.093	0.13 [-0.02, 0.28]	2.20	0.029	0.17 [0.02, 0.32]
	Love	4.24	<0.001	0.31 [0.17, 0.45]	3.50	<0.001	0.26 [0.11, 0.41]
	Total	4.69	<0.001	0.34 [0.20, 0.48]	4.31	<0.001	0.32 [0.18, 0.47]

Note: BARE = Brief Accessibility, Responsiveness, and Engagement Scale. The multiple regression statistics quantify RC/outcome relationships after controlling for participant gender, age, and relationship length.

3.7. Dyadic perspectives

3.7.1. Assortative mating

Participants with higher RC levels may gravitate toward and select partners who also possess higher RC levels. This hypothesis was supported in the form of a 0.53 ($p < .001$) correlation between participant and partner levels of RC. Thus, high RC participants may have shaped their relationships before they even began, specifically by choosing relationally competent partners.

To further examine affiliative processes, we turned to mate preference data. As a first step, we reverse scored the original ranking numbers so that high values reflected qualities that were sought or possessed. In general, participants tended to value intrinsic qualities such as kindness and similarity over extrinsic qualities such as money and status. Such rankings varied by participant RC levels, however, as revealed in a GLM analysis and an RC by quality interaction, $F(6, 1014) = 10.39, p < .001, \eta_p^2 = 0.06$. With respect to individual qualities, high RC individuals tended to rank openness, $t = 2.74, p = .007, \beta = 0.21$, similarity, $t = 4.28, p < .001, \beta = 0.31$, and kindness, $t = 3.47, p < .001, \beta = 0.26$, as more

important, while ranking status, $t = -4.23, p < .001, \beta = -0.31$, attractiveness, $t = -2.18, p = .031, \beta = -0.17$, and money, $t = -3.67, p < .001, \beta = -0.27$, as less important. Rankings for intelligence did not vary as a function of participant levels of RC, $t = -1.65, p = .101, \beta = -0.13$. Fig. 1 displays estimated means for this quality by RC interaction.

To examine relations between preferences and partner attributes, we computed within-dyad correlations across the 7 attributes. The average such correlation was 0.52 ($SD = 0.37$; range = -0.39 to 1), indicating that people tended to “get what they want” in their partners. This was truer for high RC participants than low RC participants, however, as indicated in a simple regression, $t = 4.11, p < .001, \beta = 0.30$. The data therefore point to ways in which high RC individuals appear to shape their relationships by choosing, and retaining, mates with psychological qualities that tend to benefit relationships (Sprecher & Regan, 2002).

3.7.2. Multiple regressions involving participant and partner RC levels

Given that both participant and partner levels of RC predicted partner-reported outcomes, we wanted to compare both predictors

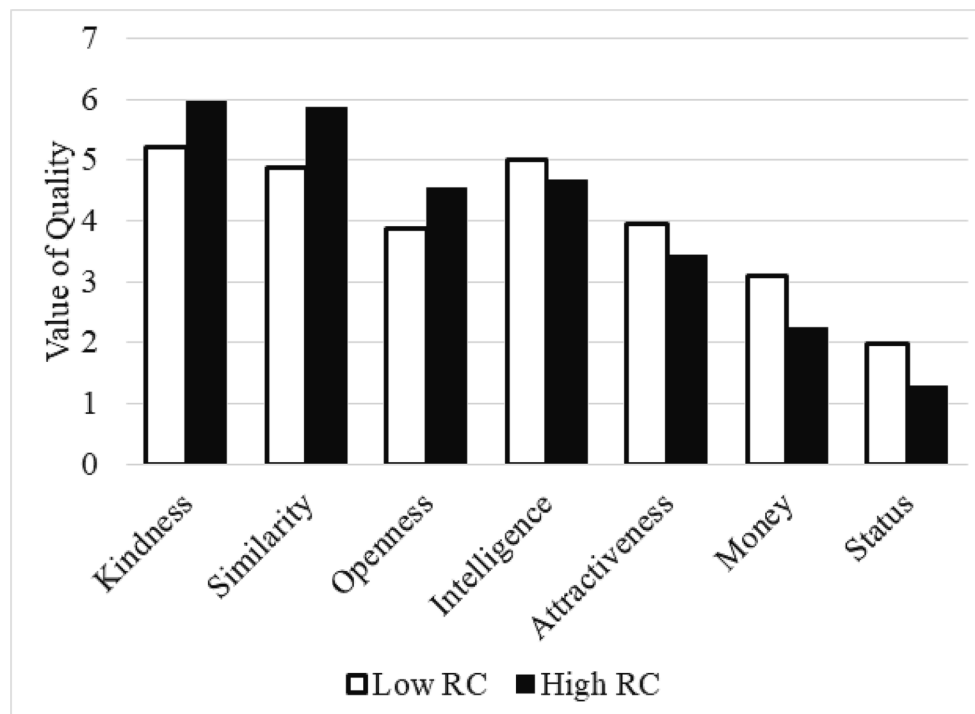


Fig. 1. Mate preference estimated means by romantic competence level (low RC = -1 SD; high RC = +1 SD).

simultaneously to investigate whether one source of RC was more predictive than the other. For the sake of parsimony, we limited the number of outcomes to total scores, where possible. We then ran a series of multiple regressions in which RC scores for both participants and partners were entered as simultaneous predictors of both participant-reported and partner-reported outcomes, with the results of these analyses reported in Table 8. Participant RC levels mattered more for the generalized outcomes that were self-reported. However, for measures that were contextualized to the current relationship, the RC levels of both participants and partners tended to matter, even when controlling for overlapping variance.

3.7.3. Actor-partner interdependence modeling

Given that we obtained RC scores from both participants and partners, and given that both participants and partners completed the same measures of relationship satisfaction (RAS scores) and quality (PRQC scores), we decided to use Actor-Partner Interdependence Modeling (APIM; Kenny, Kashy, & Cook, 2006) to further probe the data. These analyses were performed with sex (male RC level & female RC level) as a distinguishing feature, excluding homosexual couples ($n = 163$ dyads). Further, data were restructured in a pairwise format, with grand-mean centering (Kenny et al., 2006), and analyses used the SPSS macro ApimDText (Kenny, 2014). These analyses revealed a “couple” effect, whereby both one’s own RC and the RC level of one’s partner predicted relationship satisfaction and quality, both for oneself and for one’s partner, as displayed in Fig. 2.

4. Discussion

The Romantic Competence-Behavioral Tendency (RC-BT) instrument is a new test (Robinson et al., *in press*) that aims to assess whether individuals have the knowledge, skills, and abilities (KSAs) thought to be important to well-functioning relationships (for a related but different approach, see Zhou & Davila, 2019). The test focuses squarely on social cognitive processes (Shoda & Mischel, 2000) and uses an effectiveness key (McDaniel et al., 2007) to quantify the extent to which the self’s actions, in response to relationship-related scenarios, can be

characterized as competent or incompetent (Robinson et al., *in press*). Importantly, though, the test also averages across particular competence scores, resulting in a global test score that is built on bottom-up units (Grover et al., 2012). Theoretically, high RC individuals should be more competent at solving problems in their relationships (D’Zurilla, Nezu, & Maydeu-Olivares, 2004) in the context of dual motivations related to agency and warmth (Fiske, Cuddy, & Glick, 2007). Conversely, low RC individuals are thought to be reactive and self-centered in their situational responding (Robinson et al., *in press*), which should be linked to behaviors such as aggression or revenge (Boon, Deveau, & Alibhai, 2009).

Given that initial efforts were primarily centered on measurement considerations (Robinson et al., *in press*), the purpose of the present research was to better understand the pathways and mechanisms that could link variations in romantic competence (RC) to variations in relationship functioning. In this context, the present research was ambitious in that we scored the RC levels of both participants and partners, obtained data relevant to numerous posited mechanisms, and the sample was also a unique one that focused on established, long-term relationships among mature adults. Indeed, 64% of the sample were married and 95% reported having been in their current romantic relationships for over a year. In discussing the findings, we will focus on mechanisms related to perceptual, behavioral, assortative, and transactional processes.

Perceptually or attitudinally, participants with higher RC levels evaluated relationships more favorably and they were less prone to problematic doubts and worries. These links were general in nature rather than relationship-specific and the relevant results suggest that high RC individuals both view relationships more positively and possess higher confidence that they can create high-quality relationships. Such confidence, in addition to following from a previous history of success, should beget success in the relationship domain through mechanisms such as self-efficacy (Bandura, 1977) in combination with the regulatory responses that follow from it (Weiser & Weigel, 2016). It is also germane to point out that high RC individuals viewed partner behaviors more positively and they were more satisfied with their relationships. Such positive perspectives concerning one’s relationship often lead to

Table 8

Multiple regression results involving both participant and partner RC score predictors.

Outcome (Source)	T	P	β
General Attitudes (Participant-Reported)			
Participant RC	4.88	<0.001	0.40 [0.24, 0.56]
Partner RC	0.72	0.471	0.06 [-0.10, 0.22]
ROCI Total Score (Participant-Reported)			
Participant RC	-5.20	<0.001	-0.41 [-0.56, -0.25]
Partner RC	-2.17	0.032	-0.17 [-0.32, -0.02]
BARE Total Score (Participant-Reported)			
Participant RC	3.89	<0.001	0.32 [0.16, 0.49]
Partner RC	1.75	0.083	0.14 [-0.02, 0.31]
Relationship Assessment (Participant-Reported)			
Participant RC	2.91	0.004	0.25 [0.08, 0.42]
Partner RC	1.91	0.058	0.16 [-0.01, 0.33]
PRQC Total (Participant-Reported)			
Participant RC	5.58	<0.001	0.43 [0.28, 0.58]
Partner RC	1.97	0.051	0.15 [-0.001, 0.31]
BARE Total (Partner-Reported)			
Participant RC	3.03	0.003	0.25 [0.09, 0.42]
Partner RC	2.74	0.007	0.23 [0.06, 0.39]
Communication (Partner-Reported)			
Participant RC	4.20	<0.001	0.34 [0.18, 0.50]
Partner RC	2.21	0.029	0.18 [0.02, 0.34]
Prosocial Behavior (Partner-Reported)			
Participant RC	2.97	0.003	0.24 [0.08, 0.41]
Partner RC	3.20	0.002	0.26 [0.10, 0.42]
Mistreatment (Partner-Reported)			
Participant RC	-2.81	0.006	-0.23 [-0.39, -0.07]
Partner RC	-3.56	<0.001	-0.29 [-0.45, -0.13]
Antisocial Behavior (Partner-Reported)			
Participant RC	-4.04	<0.001	-0.32 [-0.48, -0.17]
Partner RC	-2.73	0.007	-0.29 [-0.38, -0.06]
Relationship Assessment (Partner-Reported)			
Participant RC	3.21	0.002	0.27 [0.10, 0.43]
Partner RC	2.11	0.036	0.18 [0.01, 0.34]
PRQC Total (Partner-Reported)			
Participant RC	4.00	<0.001	0.33 [0.17, 0.49]
Partner RC	2.01	0.046	0.16 [0.003, 0.33]

Note: R-OCI = Relationship Obsessive Compulsive Inventory; BARE = Brief Accessibility, Responsiveness, and Engagement Scale; PRQC = Perceived Relationship Quality Components.

behaviors (such as social support or responsiveness) that contribute to relationship satisfaction, including over time (Cobb, Davila, & Bradbury, 2001; Murray, Holmes, & Griffin, 1996).

Such positive perceptions, though, are likely to matter to partners

through behavioral routes and mechanisms. Consistent with this point, high RC individuals were more accessible, responsive, and engaged in their relationships, according to partners. Behaviors of this type have been shown to enhance relationship quality (Sandberg et al., 2017) and can be conceptualized in terms of both warmth and competence (Sandberg et al., 2012), which we believe are key in capturing how RC operates. Partners also reported that high RC individuals were less prone to antisocial behavior in the relationship, as suggested by Robinson et al. (in press), and they were less prone to mistreat their partners. Although additional types of behavior (e.g., maintenance behavior) would be useful to focus on in future research, the data nonetheless provide a firm foundation for thinking that RC is linked to relationship behaviors that directly affect the experiences of the partner. That the partners of high RC participants were more satisfied with their partnerships (and that this was true even after controlling for partner RC levels) reinforces this point.

The design also allowed us to track possible processes of a dyadic or interactive nature. High RC individuals perceived their partners to be more accessible, responsive, and engaged and they, in turn, exhibited these behaviors to a greater extent in the relationship, as rated by partners. Similarly, RC was linked to higher perceptions of relationship satisfaction and quality (own perceptions) as well as to experiences of satisfaction and quality among partners. The one exception was that partners did not report that their relationships with high RC participants were more passionate ones, but passion can dissipate with time (Sumter, Valkenburg, & Peter, 2013) and probably reflects mechanisms that are more physiological in nature, relative to trust, love, and commitment (Fletcher et al., 2000), which were enhanced in the context of high RC partnerships. Multiple regression results further suggested that the RC levels of both participants and partners contributed to relationship satisfaction, again for both selves and partners, and this dyadic conclusion received confirmation when using an actor-partner interdependence analysis. Overall, then, the results highlight dynamic processes that link RC to the transaction space of the relationship, extending it beyond the individual.

Lastly, the findings point to assortative mechanisms that appear to vary as a function of RC. High (relative to low) RC individuals were somewhat more interested in partners who possessed the sorts of intrinsic qualities that are thought to be important to romantic relationships (Sprecher & Regan, 2002) and they ranked extrinsic qualities such as money and status as relatively less important. Importantly, too, high RC individuals were more likely to be dating partners who

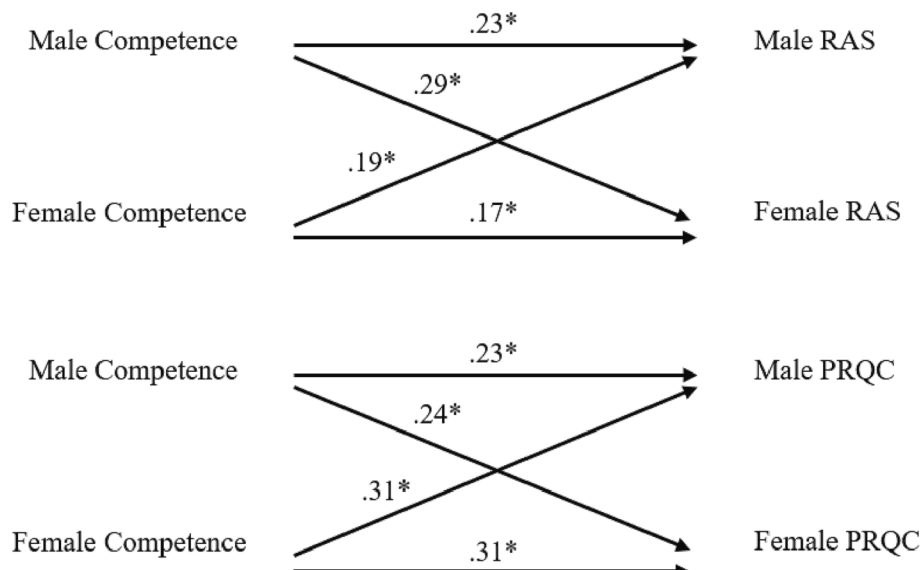


Fig. 2. Actor-partner interdependence modeling with sex as a distinguishing feature.

described themselves in terms of the qualities that were sought and the results suggested assortative matching for RC levels. The latter matching coefficient ($r = 0.53$) was a stronger one than has typically been observed with respect to dimensions of personality or cognitive ability (Luo, 2017) and the mechanisms driving this association deserve further study. Nonetheless, what we can say is that high RC levels appear to benefit relationships both because they contribute to high-quality relations and because high RC individuals choose partners who appear to possess the same sorts of skills that they do.

4.1. Further analysis, limitations, and future directions

To begin our broader discussion, we should revisit the logic of the RC-BT in relation to a series of questions, the first one being whether endorsement of simulated responses (on the RC-BT) would predict corresponding behaviors in real-life. One way to answer this question is to point to validity evidence in the personality realm. Several situational judgment tests (SJTs) have targeted particular personality traits and, in such cases, convergent validity has been established. Tangney et al. (1996) reported a 0.61 correlation between the endorsement of physically aggressive behaviors, in an SJT, and assault as measured by the Buss-Durkee hostility inventory. O'Connor, Archer, and Wu (2001) found a similar (0.65) correlation between aggressive action endorsement in response to scenarios (e.g., "I would turn around and warn them to shut up or else I would punch them") and trait physical aggression as assessed by the Buss-Perry scale. More recently, Mussel et al. (2018) reported SJT test/personality trait correlations that ranged from 0.41 (agreeableness) to 0.70 (openness to experience).

Because the RC-BT does not target personality traits, however, it is also worthwhile considering findings from the intention-behavior literature. As pointed out by Lievens and De Soete (2012), SJT responses can be considered intentions to respond in particular ways to particular situations. Intentions are considered proximate predictors of behavior in several social psychological models of decision-making and behavior (e.g., Ajzen, 1991) and intention-behavior correlations have been estimated to range from 0.40 to 0.82, with a weighted mean of 0.53, based on meta-analytic results (Sheeran, 2002). These correlations are moderate to high, but they are not 1, indicating that a number of factors are likely to moderate the intention-behavior relationship (Schwarzer, 2001; Sheeran, 2002). Overall, these literatures would suggest some correspondence between RC-BT endorsements and corresponding real-world behaviors, but such correlations would not be perfect and we should admit that we do not have direct evidence for SJT-behavior correspondence with respect to the RC-BT.

Responses to SJT scenarios are self-reported, rendering it useful to consider possible biases related to social desirability. The personnel selection literature has addressed this issue by asking some participants to "fake good" on SJT tests, the majority of which seek to assess socially skilled behavior (Christian, Edwards, & Bradley, 2010). These data are inconclusive (Zhang, Cullen, & Sackett, in press), but one thing that seems clear is that SJT tests are less vulnerable to faking than standard personality tests are (Hooper, Cullen, & Sackett, 2006), possibly because SJT tests do not involve ascribing broad traits to the self (Persich & Robinson, 2022).

Influences related to social desirability can also be assessed by obtaining social desirability ratings for a set of SJT response options and correlating them with mean rates of endorsement. Kaminski, Felfe, Schäpers, and Krumm (2019) performed such an analysis and found modest correlations (0.29 in one study and 0.17 in another). Perhaps of more importance, Kaminski et al. (2019) found a 0.13-sized correlation between the desirability of a response and how effective it was determined to be, suggesting that competency-based scoring would not reward socially desirable responding to any considerable extent. This is pertinent because RC-BT scoring is based on the effectiveness of actions and not their desirability. Regardless, we should admit that the RC-BT is a different instrument than that examined by Kaminski et al. (2019),

suggesting that more could be done to understand the role of social desirability factors (and other self-report biases) in understanding the nature of RC-BT scores.

The scoring key for the RC-BT is based on the effectiveness ratings of 148 participants involved in romantic relationships. These individuals were not selected because they are good at relationships, or necessarily know a lot about them, and the key therefore follows a "wisdom of the crowd" logic (Barchard, Hensley, & Anderson, 2013). The nature of this logic is that all individuals are likely to have some mistaken ideas concerning the effectiveness of particular ways of responding, but the mistaken ideas of one person are likely to be different than the mistaken ideas of another (Barchard et al., 2013). By aggregating a large set of effectiveness ratings, mistaken ideas would cancel each other out, resulting in reliable scoring key (Legree, Psotka, Tremble, & Bourne, 2005). As pointed out by Barchard et al. (2013), scoring keys of this type are often used when veridical answers cannot be determined in an *a priori* manner, as is almost certainly the case in the romantic relationship domain (Finkel, Simpson, & Eastwick, 2017).

With respect to a number of SJT tests, convergence between wisdom of the crowd and expert scoring keys has been established. For example, Mayer, Salovey, Caruso, and Sitarenios (2003) found that mean answer endorsements of laypersons and experts were correlated at 0.91. Of more importance, participants received scores that correlated from 0.96 to 0.98 with each other when scoring was done using one key (layperson norms) versus the other (experts). Brown, Grossenbacher, Martin-Raugh, Kochert, and Prewett (in press) made a more general case for this point by showing that the mean effectiveness ratings of uninformed MTurk raters and subject matter experts correlated from 0.88 to 0.96 with each other across diverse SJT tests focused on communication behaviors, medical knowledge, and military practices. Brown et al. (in press) do not recommend eliminating subject matter experts, but they do suggest that crowdsourced scoring keys function very similarly to expert scoring keys and an advantage of the former is that a larger number of raters can typically be obtained. Regardless, a similar analysis has not been performed with the RC-BT and expert ratings might be favored in future research.

Turning to findings from the present research, that the RC-BT predicted many relationship outcomes provides support for skill-based perspectives of relationship functioning (Burlinson, 1995; Farmer & Chapman, 2016). Of importance, we showed that the RC levels of participants predicted partner satisfaction with the relationship and cross-over from participants to partners must, at some level, implicate the behaviors that high RC participants perform in the relationship. Indeed, partners reported that participants with high RC levels were more accessible and responsive as well as less prone to antisocial behavior (among other findings).

In these reports, it is feasible that the satisfaction levels of partners influenced their reports of partner behavior (consistent with the "sentiment override" construct: Weiss, 1980), but one would still need to explain why partners were more satisfied in their relationships with participants possessing higher RC levels. In essence, behavioral mechanisms seem necessary in explaining such relationships (Davis & Oathout, 1987), and the strong correlations between participant RC and the partner-reported perceptions of behavior provide support for such a perspective. Even so, we recognize that couple behaviors can be coded from laboratory couple interactions (McNulty, Meltzer, Neff, & Karney, 2021) and obtaining measures of this type would augment our understanding of how RC manifests itself in behavioral processes (also see Zhou & Davila, 2019).

One fascinating development in this literature is the suggestion that even seemingly "positive" traits and processes such as forgiveness, benevolent partner attributions, and kindness can backfire in certain types of relationships (McNulty & Fincham, 2012). For example, forgiving a partner who engages in hostile behavior can reduce marital satisfaction over time, likely because the partner continues to act in a hostile manner (McNulty, 2008; also see Baker, McNulty, Overall,

Lambert, & Fincham, 2013). The RC-BT seems to bypass some of these complications, perhaps because effectiveness is scored with respect to a large variety of behaviors in a variety of situational contexts (Grover et al., 2012). Nonetheless, we must admit that the scenarios of the RC-BT are relatively silent on the nature of the relationship (e.g., casual versus marital) or characteristics of the partner (e.g., whether one's partner is depressed or not) and further thinking about how to use the SJT platform to incorporate contextual elements of this type might be valuable. Additionally, further research on potential moderators of RC/outcome associations might be warranted.

As to whether RC is more functional in some relationships than others, we do not know. Szepeswol and Simpson (2019) suggest that insecure attachment styles, which are generally deemed to be problematic (Feeney, 2008), could be functional if one grew up in a harsh or unpredictable environment. But in this context, functional is defined as being suited to a given life history strategy (fast or slow), based on one's upbringing. Even if functional in such terms, insecure attachment styles could still cause problems within a particular romantic relationship (Feeney, 2008). Similarly, possessing low levels of RC could "make sense" given certain environments or relationship histories, but the same lack of skills and abilities could render it unlikely that particular relationships will be successful (Simons, Simons, Lei, & Landor, 2012).

In fact, we should admit that, although we have treated RC as a predictor of relationship functioning, the skills and abilities linked to RC are likely to develop over time, in response to a variety of experiences in childhood and young adulthood. On this point, there is evidence that nurturant-involved parenting in childhood sets the stage for higher levels of romantic competence in young adulthood (Conger, Cui, Bryant, & Elder, 2000). Other developmental precursors of romantic competence appear to involve having opposite-sex siblings (Doughty, Lam, Stanik, & McHale, 2015), having good relationship with peers (Moilanen & Manuel, 2017), and maternal supportiveness concerning romantic involvement (Shulman et al., 2017). Posited mechanisms include a secure attachment style (Kumar & Mattanah, 2016) and general-purpose self-regulation skills (Moilanen & Manuel, 2017). As noted by Kumar and Mattanah (2016), research in this area has been hampered by the lack of ability-based measures of romantic competence. That the RC-BT now exists may facilitate further progress concerning developmental antecedents of the skills investigated.

There may also be reasons for thinking that RC levels could change in response to recent relationship-related experiences. For example, provocations and threats within a relationship are known to trigger revenge motivation (Boon et al., 2009) and a sufficient number of such events may alter the social cognitive processes assessed by the RC-BT, such that more vengeful responses (which tend not to be effective) are endorsed. Conversely, and just as we have suggested that high RC participants may be able to influence their partners through their behaviors, partners with high RC levels may be capable of re-shaping the self, particularly with respect to mindsets focused on mutuality and support (Sandberg et al., 2012). Indeed, there is evidence that some of the pillars that support romantic competence, such as insight and mutuality, can be taught, whether through educational workshops (Davila et al., 2021) or psychotherapy (Atzil-Slonim, Reshef, Berman, Peri, & Shulman, 2016). Longitudinal research would be particularly valuable in determining whether RC predicts relationship trajectories over time and/or responds to such trajectories.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Michelle R. Persich Durham: Conceptualization, Methodology, Writing – original draft, Project administration. **Ivy R. Bergstrom:** Conceptualization, Methodology. **Crystal M. Towers:** Conceptualization, Methodology. **Michael D. Robinson:** Conceptualization, Methodology, Supervision.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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